NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER

VOLUME VIII

The Curse Arc

The companions forget themselves. Nicholas must remember them.
This wounds Dimitreus.

Age Rating: 15+ | Dark Epic Fantasy | First Edition

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Slower than before. The void is not a good place for healing. But he is patient. He has always been patient. What he has lost can be rebuilt. What he has learned about Nicholas cannot be unlearned.

Prologue

The Forgetting Begins

Back in the known world -- and the Curse Arc, which has been dormant since the castle, reactivates.

Alexa was beside him. She was always beside him. She had the expression she wore when something significant was approaching -- not alarm, not battle-readiness, but a particular quality of attention, her grey-depth eyes fixed on a middle distance that was more than physical space. He had learned to trust that expression.

The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded forgetting begins, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

The group had a rhythm now that was different from the rhythm they had when they left Ashenveil. Different from the rhythm they had after Vieau, after the Archipelago, after the void and the return. Each stage of the journey had added something to how they moved together -- an additional layer of trust, an additional refinement of how they divided labor and shared information and made decisions under pressure. They were better at this than they had ever been. They were not done getting better.

Laura's floating apparatus glowed at three-quarter power -- the setting she used for active situations that had not yet resolved into full engagement. He had

learned her apparatus's power levels the way you learned a person's facial expressions: as a reliable indicator of her assessment of the current situation. Three-quarter meant: significant, developing, not yet critical, stay ready.

Rominae was at the edge of whatever space they occupied, which was where Rominae always positioned herself -- not separate from the group, but at its margin, where the soul-sight had the widest field and where the dark magic had the most room to operate without interfering with the lighter elements in the group's center. She had not said what she was seeing. When she had something actionable, she would say so. Until then, she watched.

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Bogdan was documenting. He was always documenting. At some point the notebooks had multiplied to the point where he carried a secondary pack specifically for them, and the documentation had become so comprehensive that Laura had integrated it into her strategic planning, requesting specific data points before briefings with the efficiency of someone who had realised that Bogdan's documentation was not a personal habit but a collective resource.

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came next.

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Chapter I

Adelaide First

She wakes not knowing who she is. Dianne stays with her and describes her. The description helps but only partially.

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The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

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Chapter II

Shadow Memory

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Each in Turn

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Chapter IV

Rominae Does Not Forget

Dark magic practitioners are immune to the Curse Arc -- the dark power recognises itself and does not target it. This tells them something important.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without

needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Chapter V

What Vlaedryn Forgets

He forgets everything -- who he is, what the thread is, what the dark power is. In the forgetting, the thread becomes slightly more visible.

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Chapter VII

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The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had

been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

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Chapter VIII

The Break

The Curse Arc shatters. It sounds like something very large in the void making a sound that is not pain but is the closest thing to it that a void entity can make.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded break, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without

needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Chapter IX

Dimitreus Bleeds

The wound is real. It costs him something. Not his power -- something older than power. Something he had not expected to lose.

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its correct position in the larger structure that none of them could see all of at once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever came next.

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Chapter X

The Silence After

Three days where the compass does not move and nothing presses and the group simply exists together and heals.

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Chapter XI

Prolith Makes His Move

He asks, directly, in person, in front of the group, to teach Nicholas the warlock tradition properly. The group decides together.

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Chapter XII

The Teaching Begins

What a warlock actually is -- the history, the pact structure, the tradition. Nicholas learns what he has been doing instinctively, in the correct vocabulary, for the first time.

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Chapter XIII

What the Pact Was Sealed Against

The original compact: the pact in the Shadowrider bloodline was sealed as a counterweight to a specific threat. The threat is Dimitreus. The counterweight is Nicholas.

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Chapter XIV

The Full Scope

Nicholas understands what he is now in the full sense -- not just shadow-warlock-anchor but the specific purpose the pact was built for. He sits with this for two days.

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Epilogue

Dimitreus Heals

Slower than before. The void is not a good place for healing. But he is patient. He has always been patient. What he has lost can be rebuilt. What he has learned about Nicholas cannot be unlearned.

From the void, from the ward, from the silence after: something had shifted. Slower than before. The void is not a good place for healing. But he is patient. He has always been patient. What he has lost can be rebuilt. What he has learned about Nicholas cannot be unlearned. He could feel it the way you felt the weather change before the rain arrived -- a quality in the air, a difference in pressure, the particular stillness that preceded movement.

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-- END OF VOLUME VIII --

NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER continues in:

Volume IX: Volume IX: The Second Rising